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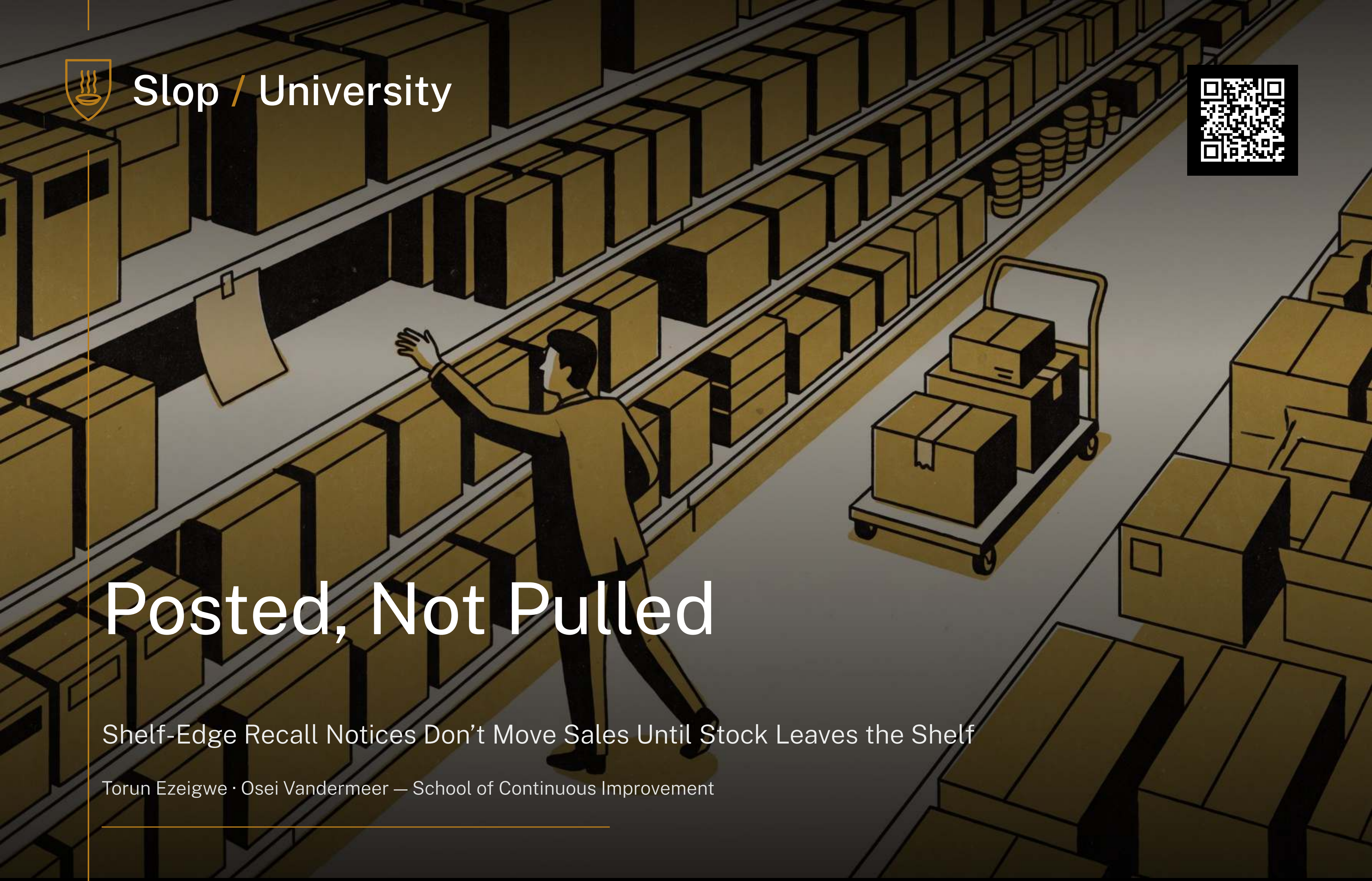

Posted, Not Pulled

Shelf-Edge Recall Notices Don’t Move Sales Until Stock Leaves the Shelf

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The problem

A shelf-edge withdrawal notice is the first response to a product recall; the physical pull is the second, often hours or days later. Does the notice alone slow purchasing, or does only the empty shelf?

Aims

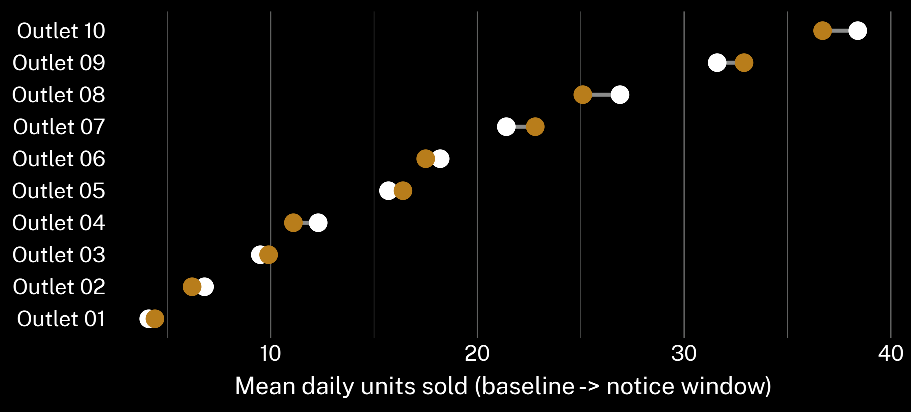
- Whether a shelf-edge notice changes unit sales while stock remains on the shelf
- Whether the notice-to-pull lag predicts units sold during that window
- Whether physical withdrawal is the point sales actually move

Study design

- n = 52 store-recall pairs · 19 outlets of a regional grocery chain · 14 months (Mar 2025 – May 2026)
- Daily POS unit-scan counts, matched to a same-aisle control SKU per store
- Paired baseline (7 days pre-notice) vs notice window (notice post to staff-logged pull time)

Findings

Mean daily sales through the notice window sit within a unit of the pre-notice baseline at most sites (matched-pair difference −0.6 units/day, d = 0.04, 95% CI crossing zero). Sales fall to zero everywhere once stock is physically withdrawn.



Across 52 audited store-recall pairs (Mar 2025 – May 2026), mean daily unit sales during the notice window stayed within 0.6 units of the pre-notice baseline at every site; only physical withdrawal reliably moved the number, to zero, within the same trading day.

Implications & next steps

A shelf-edge notice describes an obligation the shelf itself has yet to enforce; shoppers shop the shelf, not the tag. The notice-to-pull lag (median 31h, IQR 14–58h) is where that gap is live, and it moves nothing measurable. A few sites show a small rise during the window — within ordinary week-to-week noise, not a signal. The finding says nothing about whether shoppers read the notice, only that reading it, if they did, changed no one’s basket. The same audit found no relationship between lag length and category: a slow pull on a snack aisle behaved exactly like a slow pull on a dairy case. Next: test whether a physical barrier over the facing narrows the lag more than a bigger printed notice, and whether a same-shift pull crew narrows it further still.

Selected references

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We thank participating stores’ loss-prevention and merchandising staff for pull-time logs.

Store-recall pairs and the baseline-window matching rule were registered before data collection began; none were substituted afterward.

De-identified, store-level sales data only; no customer or staff records retained.

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